

BRITISH QUEEN Born 1819 Died 1901

Queen Victoria

“We are not **interested** in the possibilities of **defeat**.”

QUEEN VICTORIA, TO ARTHUR BALFOUR, MEMBER OF PARLIAMENT, 1899

Queen Victoria, the longest-reigning monarch in British history, was the only child of the Duke of Kent, fourth son of George III, and his German wife, Princess Victoria of Saxe-Coburg-Saalfeld. Fair-haired and blue-eyed, she spent most of her childhood in the seclusion of London's Kensington Palace, and had little contact with her uncle, William IV. She was 11 when she found out her royal destiny, at which point she famously declared: “I will be good.”

On the death of William IV in 1837, the 18-year-old Princess Victoria acceded to the throne. Until then, she had slept in her mother's room, and one of her first decisions, on moving into Buckingham Palace, was to insist on a bedroom of her own. In political matters,

Victoria's first prime minister, the fatherly Lord Melbourne, was her early mentor, but within a couple of years he was replaced by the love of her life, Albert of Saxe-Coburg-Gotha.

A royal courtship

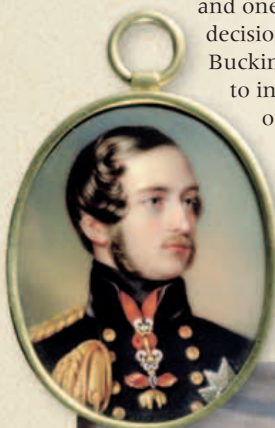
As one of Victoria's German cousins, Albert was considered an appropriate husband. He was just three months younger than Victoria—in fact, the same midwife had assisted at both of their births—but he was mature for his age. He was an

A picture of royalty

A photographic portrait of the “great white queen.” Photography, an invention of her reign, made Victoria an international icon, spreading her image around the world.

Prince Albert

Albert was married to Victoria for 21 years. After his death, Victoria reputedly made decisions based on what she thought he would have done.



The Victorian family

As a loving couple with a happy home life, the queen and her consort, seen here with some of their nine children, exemplified respectable “Victorian” family values.

